

Maintenance Retainer Proposal

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Ongoing engineering support — V1 launch & beyond

Engagement	Monthly maintenance retainer
Rate	\$2,500 / month
Hours included	25 hours / month (\$100/hr effective)
Term	Month-to-month, 30 days notice to cancel
Start date	[To be confirmed]

Overview

This retainer covers ongoing maintenance and operational support for the application post-launch. The goal is to keep the system healthy, secure, and responsive to real-user pressure as the user base grows from launch through the first several thousand active users.

Maintenance retainers are how most production apps stay production. Bugs surface, dependencies need patching, and small issues caught early prevent the kind of churn that's expensive to recover from. This is the on-call layer — not new feature development.

What's Included

- **Bug fixes** — Triage, reproduce, and resolve bugs reported by you or surfaced via monitoring. Includes regression testing and deployment.
- **Dependency upgrades** — Regular patching of npm packages, Node.js runtime, Mongoose, Express, React, and security advisories (CVEs). Aim for quarterly minor-version sweeps and immediate response on critical security patches.
- **Small UI tweaks** — Copy changes, styling adjustments, minor layout fixes, button/form behavior corrections — anything that fits comfortably in under ~2 hours of work.
- **Monitoring & oncall** — Respond to errors caught by Sentry (once wired up) and uptime alerts from Railway. Investigate, diagnose, and patch as needed.
- **Infrastructure hygiene** — MongoDB Atlas index review, Railway resource monitoring, Twilio/Google Places usage review, log rotation, backup verification.

- **Light user support escalation** — When a user issue is technical (auth failures, SMS not arriving, plan data weirdness), I'll investigate the backend and report back. Frontline user support stays with you.
- **Monthly status report** — Short written summary at month-end: what was fixed, what's pending, hours used, any patterns or risks I noticed.

What's Not Included

The following work falls outside the maintenance retainer and is scoped separately as fixed-bid or hourly projects:

- **New features** — Anything that adds new user-facing functionality (new screens, new flows, new integrations).
- **Major migrations** — e.g. moving the in-memory store from data.json to MongoDB, switching SMS to push notifications, wrapping the app for native iOS/Android.
- **Redesigns** — Visual overhauls, component library swaps, or significant UX restructuring.
- **Third-party account setup** — Twilio A2P 10DLC registration, Apple/Google Play submission, domain transfers — happy to consult, but the account-holder work is yours.
- **After-hours emergency response** — Standard response is business hours (see SLA below). Genuine 2am production outages can be covered, billed at 1.5x outside business hours.

Response Times

Business hours are Mon–Fri, 9am–6pm ET. Response time is acknowledgment, not resolution — actual fix time depends on complexity.

Severity	Definition	Response time
P0 — Critical	Site down, auth broken, data loss, payments failing	Within 2 business hours
P1 — High	Major feature broken for most users, no workaround	Same business day
P2 — Medium	Feature broken for some users, or has workaround	Within 2 business days
P3 — Low	Cosmetic, minor, or nice-to-have	Within the current sprint/month

Hours & Billing

- **Monthly fee:** \$2,500, invoiced on the 1st of each month, due net-15.

- **Included hours:** 25 hours per month. I track time and share a brief log with each monthly report.
- **Rollover:** Up to 10 unused hours roll into the following month. Beyond that, unused hours don't carry.
- **Overage:** Hours beyond 25/month billed at \$125/hr, with prior notice once we cross 22 hours so you can decide whether to defer non-urgent work.
- **Out-of-scope work:** Quoted separately as fixed-bid (for clearly scoped features) or T&M at \$125/hr (for exploratory work).
- **Expenses:** Any paid services or tools needed for the work (test accounts, one-off dev tools) pre-approved before purchase and billed at cost.

Communication

- **Primary channel:** Email or Slack (whichever you prefer) for non-urgent work.
- **Urgent issues:** Text/phone for P0 and P1 incidents during business hours.
- **Issue tracking:** GitHub Issues, Linear, or whatever you already use — happy to fit your existing workflow.
- **Weekly check-in:** Optional 20-minute call if you want one. Otherwise, async via the monthly report and ad-hoc updates as work is completed.

Terms

- **Term:** Month-to-month. Either party can cancel with 30 days written notice.
- **Code ownership:** You own all code I write under this retainer. I retain the right to reference general patterns and approaches in my portfolio (no proprietary details).
- **Infrastructure accounts:** All third-party accounts (Railway, MongoDB Atlas, Twilio, Google Cloud, domain registrar) are owned and paid for by you. I work with delegated access.
- **Offboarding:** If we wind down, I'll provide a written handoff document covering architecture, deployment, known issues, and access transfer — included in the final month's hours.
- **Confidentiality:** Standard mutual NDA. Happy to sign one you already use, or I can provide a template.
- **Liability:** Capped at fees paid in the prior 3 months. Standard professional indemnity — not responsible for issues outside my control (third-party outages, infrastructure failures, etc.).

Why This Structure

A few notes on the shape of this proposal, in case useful:

- **25 hours is a real cushion.** Most months will use less. The buffer is there for the bad weeks — a Twilio API change, a Mongoose breaking update, a user-reported bug that takes a day to track down. Paying for the capacity to respond is what makes the retainer worth more than ad-hoc billing.
- **Month-to-month, not annual.** You shouldn't be locked in. If the app stabilizes and doesn't need 25 hours, we can renegotiate down. If it grows fast and needs more, we can scale up. Annual contracts make sense at higher tiers, not this one.
- **Clear scope boundaries.** The biggest source of retainer friction is “does this count?” for borderline work. The included/not-included split above is meant to make those conversations short — if it's in the list, we just do it; if not, I'll quote it before starting.

Next Steps

1. Confirm start date and preferred communication channel.
2. Sign engagement letter (I can send a short one based on this proposal).
3. Grant delegated access to Railway, MongoDB Atlas, Twilio, Google Cloud, and the repo.
4. Decide on issue-tracking workflow (Suitenote, dedicated email thread,).
5. First invoice goes out on the agreed start date.